

Cultural probes

What this tool produces · *A collection of self-documented, highly personal data (diaries, photographs, emotional responses) that reveals the lived experiences and latent desires of the community .*

G1 · Proof of Impact

Dimensions

Social / User

Heritage

Preparing the workshop · *Cultural probes*

G1 · Proof of Impact

Why this tool matters

Engaging participants in imaginative and playful participation, allowing them to capture the poetry of their daily lives on their own terms rather than answering sterile survey questions .

Evidence we produce

A collection of self-documented, highly personal data (diaries, photographs, emotional responses) that reveals the lived experiences and latent desires of the community .

Duration & Material

Duration · 1 to 2 weeks of participant self-tracking

Material · Custom probe kits (cameras, printed maps, logbooks, stamped envelopes)

Reference case

In a multi-national project aimed at increasing the presence of the elderly in local communities, researchers deployed Cultural Probes. In Peccioli (Italy), the probes helped uncover a relaxed community in a beautiful setting, leading planners to focus on amplifying social and pastoral soundscapes. In Oslo, the probes engaged an educated community, prompting elders to lead community-wide conversations on social issues , .

Suggested agenda · Brief (10 min) > Method walk-through (15 min) > Animation canvas (60-90 min) > Harvest (20 min)

Probe kit design · self-tracking by participants

Duration
1 to 2 weeks of participant self-tracking

Disposable camera
*Capture 5 daily moments
(noise, shelter, joy)*

kit content

Daily diary
*Log routines in your
own words & pace*

kit content

Personal map
*Sketch your routes,
fears, favourite places*

kit content

Postcards
*Reply to 5 prompts,
return by post*

kit content

2-week self-tracking schedule

D1	D2	D3	D4	D5	D6	D7	D8	D9	D10	D11	D12	D13	D14
----	----	----	----	----	----	----	----	----	-----	-----	-----	-----	-----

Pattern synthesis · what the kits tell us

Harvesting our *learnings*

After running the canvas, capture three layers of insight.

What inspires me

Stand-out signals, surprising stories, ideas to remember

How to apply it here

Concrete adaptations to our context, our team, our constraints

What we need to be autonomous

Skills, allies, resources, decisions still to secure

Each participant fills a copy. Then debrief together to surface patterns and next steps.